English • Integrity, resilience and poetic form

If

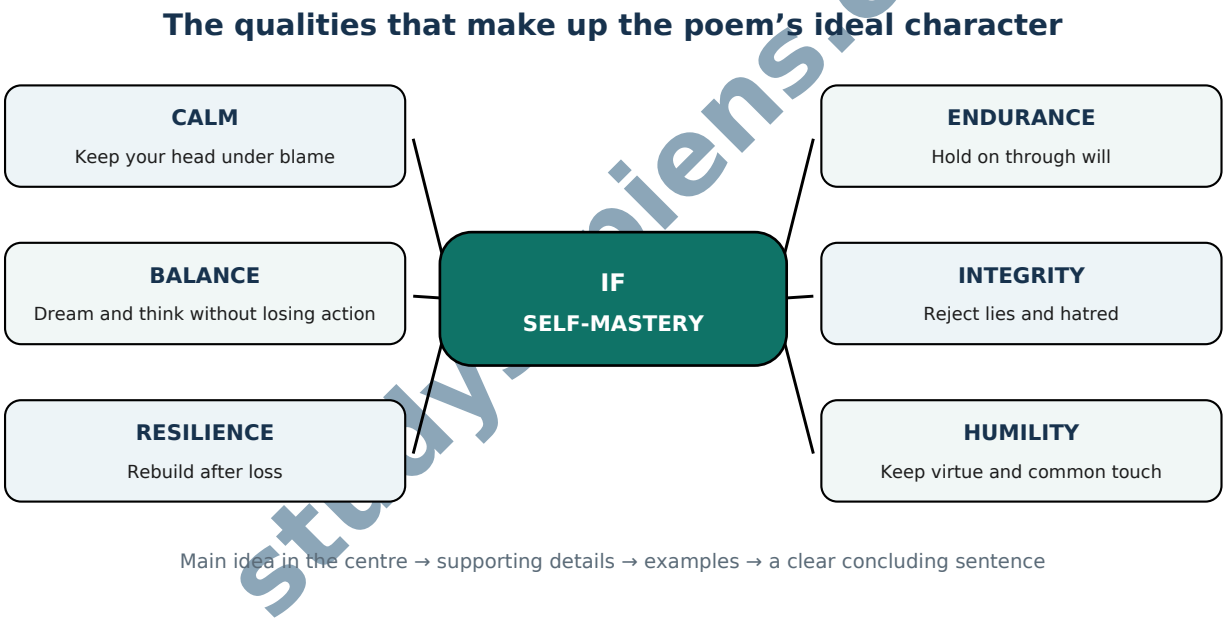
Rudyard Kipling • Official activities • Stanza paraphrases • Conjunctions • Summary

Unit 7 • Poem • Complete official activities • Paraphrase + Grammar + Summary

Poem at a glance

• **Poet:** Rudyard Kipling (1865–1936), an English author, poet and journalist whose work was shaped by his birth and early life in colonial India.
• **Central idea:** Mature character requires self-command, patience, honesty, resilience, humility and balanced judgement in both success and adversity.
• **Form:** Four eight-line stanzas, predominantly iambic pentameter, with a broad **ABABCDCD** rhyme pattern and a final address to “my son”.
• **Key techniques:** Anaphora, conditional clauses, personification, metaphor, antithesis, symbolism and didactic direct address.

Figure 1 — Original map of Kipling’s interlocking virtues



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Interpretive note: The closing phrase “you’ll be a Man, my son” reflects the poem’s historical wording. Its qualities of maturity, integrity and perseverance can be applied by readers of any gender.

Pre-Reading and While-Reading

P1. Which qualities maintain integrity and resilience in difficult situations?

Integrity requires honesty, consistent principles and the humility to examine one’s own mistakes. Resilience requires patience, realistic hope, emotional control and willingness to begin again. Self-trust must be balanced with openness to fair criticism; courage must be joined with compassion so that persistence does not become stubbornness or hostility.

P2. Predict the poem's themes from this discussion.

The poem is likely to present a code of mature conduct: staying calm under pressure, resisting dishonesty, using ambitions wisely, enduring loss and treating success and failure with balance. The repeated conditional "if" may lead to a final reward or description of complete character.

Margin 1. How will you handle failure in your life?

Model response: I will acknowledge the disappointment without calling myself a failure. Then I will identify what was within my control, seek constructive feedback, repair what can be repaired and begin again with a revised plan. I will not hide the loss or abandon my values to appear successful.

Margin 2. How will you celebrate success in your life?

I will thank the people who supported me, recognize the effort involved and enjoy the achievement without boasting. I will also review what worked, share useful knowledge and set a new goal. This response treats success as an opportunity for gratitude and further growth rather than proof of superiority.

Stanza-by-Stanza Guide

Stanza	Meaning and development
1 — Self-command	Remain calm when others panic or blame you. Trust yourself without dismissing others' doubts; wait patiently, reject lies and hatred, and avoid appearing self-satisfied or speaking as if you know everything.
2 — Balance and rebuilding	Use dreams and thought without letting them replace action. Treat success and disaster as temporary and deceptive. Endure distortion of your words and damage to your achievements, then rebuild with whatever limited tools remain.
3 — Risk and endurance	Be willing to risk accumulated success for a worthy purpose, lose it and begin again without complaint. When physical and emotional energy seems exhausted, let determination sustain your effort.

Stanza	Meaning and development
4 — Integrity and fulfilment	Mix with ordinary people or rulers without losing virtue or humility. Value every person without becoming dependent on any one person's approval, and use each minute fully. These qualities produce mature character and a rich life.

Sound and structure. How form reinforces meaning.

• **Anaphora:** Repeated "If you can" accumulates conditions and mirrors the sustained discipline demanded by the poem.

• **Conditional structure:** The long series of "if" clauses delays the main result until the final stanza, creating anticipation and a satisfying conclusion.

• **Rhyme and metre:** The broad ABABCDCD pattern and regular ten-syllable movement give the advice order and authority; occasional metrical variation prevents a mechanical effect.

• **Antithesis:** Triumph/Disaster, Kings/common touch and friends/foes present extremes that a balanced person must navigate.

Reading and Critical Thinking

1. According to the poet, how should one respond to criticism and blame?

One should remain calm when others lose control and assign blame. Self-trust is important, but it should not produce arrogance: the listener should make allowance for other people's doubts and examine whether their criticism contains something useful. The response should therefore be composed, honest and thoughtful rather than defensive or abusive.

2. What quality does the poem emphasize in handling doubt and self-trust?

It emphasizes **balanced confidence**. A person must not collapse merely because others express doubt, yet should remain humble enough to understand their reservations. This is neither dependence on public approval nor refusal to listen; it is independent judgement joined with open-mindedness.

3. What message does the poem give about dreams and aspirations?

Dreams are valuable, but they must not become one's master. Aspirations should guide practical effort rather than trap a person in fantasy. Likewise, thinking should not become an end in itself that replaces action. The poem calls for imaginative and intellectual life controlled by purpose, realism and responsibility.

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4. How should a person handle twisted truths and personal losses?

A person should endure hearing honest words distorted by dishonest people without adopting their methods. When cherished work is damaged, the response should not be surrender or public self-pity but patient reconstruction. Truthfulness, emotional restraint and practical repair are more powerful than retaliation or despair.

5. What does the poem suggest about resilience and rebuilding after setbacks?

Resilience means starting again after severe loss, even when resources are “worn-out” and recognition is absent. It also means accepting that success can be fragile without becoming paralysed by that knowledge. The ability to rebuild quietly demonstrates character more convincingly than an uninterrupted record of easy victories.

6. According to the poem, how should one persist in difficult times?

One should continue when heart, nerve and sinew feel exhausted and only willpower remains. The repeated command “Hold on!” presents endurance as an inner decision. In healthy practice, this determination should be purposeful rather than reckless: perseverance does not require ignoring injury or refusing necessary help.

7. What is the poem’s message about integrity and humility?

Integrity means keeping virtue in a crowd, refusing hatred and lies, and remaining truthful when others distort one’s words. Humility means retaining the common touch among kings, avoiding a superior appearance and valuing people without allowing anyone to dominate one’s identity. Power, popularity and status must not change moral conduct.

Vocabulary: Contextual Clues and Poetic Language

Expression	Meaning inferred from context
dreams your master	allowing aspirations to control you instead of directing them towards realistic action
Triumph and Disaster … impostors	success and failure personified as deceptive appearances; neither is final or a complete measure of worth
knaves	dishonest people who twist truth to trap others
worn-out tools	limited or exhausted resources still used for rebuilding
heart and nerve and sinew	physical, emotional and mental strength represented through body imagery

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Expression	Meaning inferred from context
the common touch	the ability to relate respectfully to ordinary people despite status
unforgiving minute	time personified as something that cannot be recovered once wasted
sixty seconds' worth of distance run	using every available moment with full effort and purpose

Glossary support: *Triumph* = great victory; *impostor* = someone or something deceptively appearing to be what it is not; *stoop* = bend down; *sinew* = tendon, here suggesting strength; *virtue* = morally good behaviour.

Figurative Language

A. Identify the figure of speech in each sentence.

Sentence	Type and explanation
The water was as cold as ice.	Simile — comparison using "as".
The car was moving as slowly as a snail.	Simile — speed compared using "as ... as".
The leaves waved goodbye as they fell.	Personification — leaves perform a human farewell.
The alarm clock screamed at me.	Personification — the clock is given a human cry.
His temper was a volcano, ready to erupt.	Metaphor — temper directly described as a volcano, suggesting explosive anger.
Her laughter was a sweet symphony.	Metaphor — laughter directly compared with harmonious music.

Poem devices. Evidence beyond the six grammar sentences.

Device	Example and effect
Personification	Triumph and Disaster are "impostors"; the minute is "unforgiving". Abstract experiences become forces a person must answer.
Metaphor	Dreams have a "master"; the Will tells the body to hold on. These images explain self-control and endurance.

Device	Example and effect
Anaphora	“If you can” begins successive conditions, creating rhythm and cumulative pressure.
Antithesis	Kings/common touch, friends/foes and Triumph/Disaster define balance between opposites.
Symbolism	Worn-out tools symbolize depleted means with which a resilient person can still rebuild.

Grammar: Conjunctions and Transitions

A. Fill in appropriate conjunctions or transitional devices.

1. We go to the garden **and** plant trees.

2. He studied hard, **but** he failed in the exams.

3. It was hot outside, **so** we went back to our homes.

4. She was tired, **but** she did not give up the work.

5. She is **both** intelligent **and** hardworking.

6. **Both** the manager **and** the employees knew about the change.

7. You can **either** read the book **or** watch the movie.

8. The dish was **as** delicious **as** it looked.

B. Join each pair by adding conjunctions.

1. You can have ice cream **or** cake for dessert.

2. He was tired, **but** he continued to work.

3. They didn’t have enough money, **so** they couldn’t buy the tickets.

4. You should wear a coat **because** it is cold outside.

5. The restaurant serves **not only** delicious food **but also** great service.

C. Write a story using conjunctions and transitions.

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Model story — The Missing Sapling

• On the first morning of the gardening club, Hina discovered that the class sapling was missing. She wanted to accuse someone immediately, **but** she decided to investigate **before** making a claim. **First**, she examined the soil and noticed a trail of water leading towards the fence.

• **Meanwhile**, her friend Daniyal found the gardener holding a small pot. He explained that he had moved the sapling **because** its original position flooded whenever the field was watered. Hina felt relieved, **yet** she also realized that the class should have been informed.

• **Therefore**, the students prepared a simple map showing where every plant belonged. **Both** the gardener **and** the club members agreed to record future changes. The sapling recovered in its new position, and the students learned that patience and communication can prevent a small mystery from becoming an unfair accusation.

Oral Communication Skills

A. Group discussion: “The Impact of Excessive Screen Time on Mental Health”.

Model discussion contribution

• Excessive recreational screen time can displace sleep, exercise, face-to-face conversation and focused study. Constant comparison on social media may increase anxiety or dissatisfaction, while frequent notifications can fragment attention. However, screens are not inherently harmful: educational content, creative work and supportive communication can be valuable. The key issues are duration, content, purpose and what the activity replaces.

• A practical response is to establish device-free sleep and meal periods, silence non-essential notifications and take regular outdoor breaks. If low mood, sleep disturbance or anxiety persists, a student should speak to a trusted adult or qualified health professional rather than relying on online diagnosis. Our group therefore recommends balanced, intentional use rather than either unlimited access or total rejection of technology.

B. Practise the gardening dialogue in turns.

Condensed speaking model

• **Zaaraa:** “Are you joining the gardening club? I thought gardening was only planting flowers.”
Kiran: “It also supports relaxation and habitats, and it teaches responsibility. Plants photosynthesize, taking in carbon dioxide and releasing oxygen.”
• **Zaaraa:** “How can it reduce stress?”
Kiran: “Time outdoors, purposeful movement and contact with soil and living things can provide a break from screens. Growing food can also encourage interest in healthy eating.”
• **Zaaraa:** “I would like to try it at home.”
Kiran: “Start with a suitable local plant, learn its water needs and share any surplus produce. I will help you choose.”

Recitation focus: Use a questioning rise for genuine enquiries, stress key content words such as *habitats*, *relaxation* and *responsibility*, and pause at sentence boundaries. Do not claim gardening is a substitute for professional mental-health care when such care is needed.

C. Compose and recite an original poem; discuss themes and feedback.

Original poem — Begin Again

• When plans lie scattered on the floor,
And doubt has locked the seeming door,
Take one small tool, one steady breath,
And build from what remaineth yet.
• Let praise not make your steps too loud,
Let loss not wrap you in its shroud;
Through crowded noise or silent rain,
Keep faith, begin, and begin again.

Theme: hopeful resilience without boasting or denial of loss. **Peer feedback:** comment on audibility, pace, emotional emphasis and clarity of theme; suggest one specific improvement rather than offering vague praise.

Paraphrasing: Required Stanzas

A. Paraphrase the second and third stanzas using synonyms, changed word forms and rearranged structures.

Second stanza — model paraphrase

• Pursue your ambitions without allowing them to dominate your behaviour, and value reflection without letting it become a substitute for purposeful action. When you experience great success or severe failure, recognize that both can mislead you because neither is permanent nor a complete measure of your worth. Remain patient if dishonest people distort your truthful statements to deceive others. If the work to which you devoted yourself is damaged, accept the loss and patiently reconstruct it even with old, limited or inadequate resources.

Third stanza — model paraphrase

• Be prepared to gather everything you have achieved and place it at risk in a single bold undertaking. If you lose it all, return to the beginning without advertising your disappointment or complaining about the loss. When your emotional strength, courage and physical energy seem completely exhausted, direct them to continue serving your purpose. Even when nothing appears to remain within you, let your determination command you to endure and hold on.

Paraphrase check: These versions preserve all major images and conditions but use fresh sentence structures and prose. A paraphrase should not compress away the poem's meaning as a summary does.

Summary Writing

B. Write an objective summary of "If".

Model objective summary

• In "If", Rudyard Kipling presents a series of conditions that define mature and resilient character. The speaker advises remaining calm under blame, trusting oneself while respecting others' doubts, and rejecting lies, hatred and arrogance. Dreams and thought should guide action rather than replace it, while success and failure should be treated as temporary and deceptive. A person should endure distorted truth, rebuild damaged work, begin again after loss without complaint and persist through exhaustion by force of will. The final stanza calls for virtue among crowds, humility among rulers, independence from excessive approval and full use of every minute. Fulfilling these demanding conditions promises a fulfilled life and mature character.

Original Exam-Practice MCQs

1. The repeated phrase "If you can" is an example of:

(a) anaphora (b) euphemism
(c) oxymoron (d) assonance only

Answer: (a) anaphora — Successive clauses begin with the same words.

2. "Make allowance for their doubting too" advises:

(a) rejecting every critic (b) balanced openness to others' doubts
(c) abandoning self-trust (d) public complaint

Answer: (b) balanced openness to others' doubts — Confidence should remain humble and thoughtful.

3. Dreams should not become one’s:

(a) master (b) tool
(c) goal (d) guide

Answer: (a) master — Ambition must not control conduct or replace action.

4. Triumph and Disaster are called impostors because they:

(a) are always imaginary (b) can mislead us about permanence and worth
(c) are dishonest people (d) cancel all effort

Answer: (b) can mislead us about permanence and worth — Neither success nor failure should define identity.

5. “Worn-out tools” primarily symbolize:

(a) limited resources for rebuilding (b) new technology
(c) complete surrender (d) public fame

Answer: (a) limited resources for rebuilding — The speaker rebuilds despite depleted means.

6. The instruction “Hold on!” emphasizes:

(a) boasting (b) endurance
(c) impatience (d) doubt

Answer: (b) endurance — Will sustains effort at exhaustion.

7. Keeping “the common touch” means:

(a) avoiding all rulers (b) remaining able to relate to ordinary people
(c) following every crowd (d) refusing friendship

Answer: (b) remaining able to relate to ordinary people — Status should not destroy humility.

8. “As cold as ice” is a:

(a) simile (b) metaphor
(c) personification (d) conjunction

Answer: (a) simile — It compares with “as”.

9. “Both … and” is a pair of:

(a) subordinating conjunctions (b) correlative conjunctions
(c) prepositions (d) transitions only

Answer: (b) correlative conjunctions — The two connectors work together.

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10. An objective poem summary should:

(a) retell every line

(b) state central advice and development without personal opinion

(c) add a personal failure story

(d) analyze only rhyme

Answer: (b) state central advice and development without personal opinion — A summary condenses essential content and theme.

Points to Remember

Four movements: self-command → balance and rebuilding → risk and endurance → integrity and mature fulfilment.

Core virtues: calm, balanced confidence, patience, honesty, resilience, will, humility and full use of time.

Form: four octaves, broad ABABCDCD rhyme, predominantly iambic pentameter and repeated conditional clauses.

Devices: anaphora, personification, metaphor, antithesis, symbolism and direct address.

Paraphrase: preserve detailed meaning in new prose; **summary:** condense central ideas.

Conjunctions: identify addition, contrast, cause, choice, comparison or paired structure before filling a blank.

Screen-time discussion: distinguish intentional use from excessive use and avoid unsupported medical claims.

MCQ key at a glance

Q	Key	Q	Key	Q	Key	Q	Key	Q	Key
1	a	2	b	3	a	4	b	5	a
6	b	7	b	8	a	9	b	10	b

How to attempt this unit in the paper

- For any “If” question, quote a short phrase and explain the virtue rather than listing every stanza.
- Do not confuse “treat impostors just the same” with indifference to effort; it means steadiness before success and failure.
- In paraphrase, retain all conditions and images; in summary, keep only the central progression.
- For conjunction blanks, read the complete sentence and check logic as well as grammatical pairing.
- When reciting an original poem, speak audibly, mark deliberate pauses and be ready to identify its theme.

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